Lesson 4 · Check before you trust · for your pupils

Spot the made-up fact

40 minutes | Ages 10–16 · adapt for other ages below | No electricity needed | No devices needed | Photocopy-friendly

Big question

If an answer sounds sure, does that make it true?

Pupils will be able to...

- Explain that a chatbot can sound sure and still be wrong.
- Name ways to check a fact: a textbook, a teacher, a library or an elder.
- Use Ask → Check → Decide, and keep personal details private.

You need

- Board and chalk (or paper on the wall)
- Five statements on a slip: four true, one made up
- Your pupils' textbook (and an atlas, if you have one)
- Worksheet: Fact detectives (one per pair, optional)

Before class

Pick four true facts from your pupils' textbook and note each page. Write one false statement that sounds just as sure, such as "Bats are birds." Prepare three more statements for pair talk.

Time	What you do	What you can say	Pupils
Warm-up 0–5 min	Ask: "A friend tells you something surprising. How do you find out if it's true?" List pupils' ideas on the board.	*"Does saying something confidently make it true?"*	Share how they check things they hear.
Teach 5–13 min	Explain that chatbots are computer programs — not robots — that write by guessing likely words. Draw a speech bubble with a question mark.	*"A chatbot writes the words that usually come next. It doesn't check facts like a careful person, so it can sound sure and still be wrong."*	Explain the idea to a partner in their own words.
Spot it 13–25 min	Read the five statements in a confident 'robot' voice. Pupils vote for the made-up one with one to five fingers. Ask two pupils how they would check, then show the textbook page.	*"I am a pretend chatbot, and I always sound sure! Which statement did I make up — and how could you check?"*	Vote, explain, and name a way to check: textbook, teacher, library or an elder.
Pair talk 25–33 min	Write the three extra statements on the board. Pairs decide: true or made up? Where could they check, and who could they ask? Check one together.	*"Where could we check this, and who could we ask?"*	Discuss in pairs and share their ideas.
Wrap-up 33–40 min	Write Ask → Check → Decide on the board. Add: never type your name, address, phone number or photo into a chatbot. Exit ticket: one fact and where to check it.	*"Ask clearly and keep personal details private. Check in a trusted place. Then decide for yourself."*	Copy the three steps; complete the exit ticket.

Check understanding
Listen for pupils naming a real way to check — a textbook, a teacher, a library or an elder. If someone says "it sounds true", ask: "How could we find out for sure?"

Exit ticket
One fact I learned today, and where I would check it.

Common mix-ups

Pupils may think...	Help them see...
If it sounds sure, it must be true.	Replay the robot voice: it sounded just as sure when it was wrong. Ask: "How could we check?"
The chatbot lied on purpose.	It didn't choose to lie. It guesses likely words, and sometimes the guess is wrong — so we check.
Telling a chatbot my name and number is fine.	Keep personal details private — name, address, phone number and photos. Ask a trusted adult before using any chatbot.

Adapt it

Younger pupils
Ages 6–9: use three short statements about animals or school. Pupils show thumbs up for true and thumbs down for made up, then say who they could ask.

Older pupils and university
Write a chatbot-style answer on the board that names a book. Pupils check each fact, look for the book in a library, and learn the word "hallucination".

Large classes
Vote with one to five fingers; row leaders count and report. In pair talk, give one statement per row instead of per pair.

No board or no space
Say the three steps aloud with an action for each: hand at mouth (ask), hand shading eyes (check), thumbs up (decide). Pupils copy you.

Short on time? Do the robot-voice vote with three statements, then write Ask → Check → Decide on the board (15 minutes).

What you need to know

AI can be useful, but it gives predictions, not checked facts — so a sure-sounding answer can be wrong. Ask clearly, check what matters in a trusted source, then decide: you stay in charge.

Chatbot (a type of generative AI)
An AI tool that creates new text when you ask. It writes by predicting likely next words, using patterns from huge amounts of text.

Trusted source
A place to check facts where a known person or organisation is responsible for getting them right — your textbook, an official website, or a colleague who knows the subject.

Hallucination
When an AI gives an answer that sounds sure and believable but is false — for example, a made-up fact, quote or source. The AI isn't lying on purpose.

Trusting the machine too much (automation bias)
Trusting a machine's answer more than you should — accepting it without checking, even when it is wrong.

My notes — how did it go?